

BEFORE YOU LAND™

The Before You Land™ Checklist

Every document, task, and deadline between today and your first week in America — in one place, in the right order.



Created by **Nii Obodai** × **Travedconsult.com**

FREE EDITION · FALL INTAKE

FOR INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS

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How to use this checklist

Moving countries is not one big task — it's about sixty small ones. Miss the wrong one and you're standing at a visa counter or an airport desk wishing you'd known. This checklist puts them in order so nothing sneaks up on you.

Work through it phase by phase. Print it or keep it on your phone, and tick things off as you go. Items marked **▲ critical** can delay your travel or your entry into the U.S. if they slip — do those first, always.

REAL TALK

The students who struggle in their first month aren't the ones who forgot a phone charger. They're the ones who packed their I-20 in a checked bag, arrived with no way to pay for anything for three days, or never told their bank they were leaving. Paperwork and money first. Everything else is replaceable.

PHASE 1 · 60-90 DAYS BEFORE YOU FLY

Lock down the paperwork

- ☐ **Check your passport validity. ▲ critical**
It should be valid at least six months beyond your planned stay. Renewals can take weeks — start now if you're close.
- ☐ **Receive and review your I-20 (or DS-2019). ▲ critical**
Check that your name matches your passport exactly, and that the program dates and funding amounts are correct. Errors here cause visa problems.
- ☐ **Pay your SEVIS I-901 fee and save the receipt. ▲ critical**
You need proof of payment for your visa interview and it's smart to carry it when you travel.
- ☐ **Complete your visa application and attend your interview (if you haven't already). ▲ critical**
- ☐ **Confirm your admission and housing.**
On-campus housing fills up. If you're going off-campus, start researching neighborhoods and typical rents near your school now.
- ☐ **Plan how you'll show proof of funds.**
Bank statements or sponsor letters may be requested at the visa stage and occasionally at the border. Keep clean copies.
- ☐ **Book your flight — but check your I-20 start date first.**
On an F-1 visa you can enter the U.S. up to 30 days before your program start date, not earlier.
- ☐ **Ask your school about arrival services.**
Many schools run airport pickups, temporary housing, and international student orientation. These are usually first-come, first-served.

PHASE 2 · 30 DAYS OUT

Money, medicine, and logistics

- ☐ **Sort your health insurance.** ▲ critical
Check whether your school enrolls you automatically or you must choose a plan. Never plan to arrive uninsured — one ER visit can cost thousands.
- ☐ **See your doctor and dentist.**
Get checkups, required vaccinations, and vaccination records translated into English. Dental work is far cheaper at home.
- ☐ **Get prescriptions sorted.**
Carry enough medication for your first 90 days, in original packaging, with a doctor's letter naming the generic drug — brand names differ across countries.
- ☐ **Plan your first-month money.**
Decide how much you'll carry and how: some cash for the first days, an international card that works in the U.S., and a plan for transferring more once you open a U.S. account.
- ☐ **Tell your home bank you're moving.**
Otherwise your first U.S. transaction may freeze your card — usually at the worst possible moment.
- ☐ **Gather your academic documents.**
Official transcripts, degree certificates, test scores. Some departments and future employers will ask for originals.
- ☐ **Arrange housing for your first nights** if your lease or dorm doesn't start on arrival day.
- ☐ **Check your airline's baggage rules** and weigh what two suitcases really allow before you start buying things to bring.

PHASE 3 · 2 WEEKS OUT

Pack smart, prep your phone

- ☐ **Build your documents folder.** ▲ critical
Passport, visa, I-20, SEVIS receipt, admission letter, proof of funds, insurance card, prescriptions, vaccination records — originals in your carry-on, scanned copies in cloud storage, one photocopy set in your checked bag.
- ☐ **Decide your U.S. phone plan strategy.**
Check if your phone is unlocked. Research prepaid or student SIM/eSIM options so you can get connected within a day of landing.
- ☐ **Download the essentials before you fly:** maps, your airline app, a rideshare app, WhatsApp, your school's app, and offline maps of your new city.
- ☐ **Save key contacts:** your school's international student office (your DSO), your country's nearest embassy or consulate, your airport pickup or host, and one family member labeled as an emergency contact.
- ☐ **Pack using a real checklist, not vibes.**
Documents and medicines first, electronics with plug adapters second, clothing third. (The full Packing Guide in the Survival Kit covers what to bring, what to buy in the U.S., and what customs won't allow.)

- ☐ **Get some U.S. dollars in cash** — enough for a taxi, food, and surprises in your first days. Small bills are more useful than large ones.

PHASE 4 · 48 HOURS & FLIGHT DAY

Fly like you've done this before

- ☐ **Check in online and confirm your baggage allowance.**
- ☐ **Charge everything** — phone, power bank, laptop. Airport-to-dorm day is long.
- ☐ **Carry-on audit: ▲ critical**
documents folder, medicines, one change of clothes, valuables, laptop, chargers, some cash. If your checked bag is delayed, you can still function.
- ☐ **Know your port-of-entry answers.**
The CBP officer will likely ask what school you're attending, what you're studying, and where you'll live. Answer simply and honestly — this is routine, not a trap.
- ☐ **Keep your I-20 and passport on your body, never in checked luggage. ▲ critical**
- ☐ **Screenshot your arrival plan:** address of where you're sleeping tonight, pickup details, and directions — in case you land with no data.

PHASE 5 · YOUR FIRST 72 HOURS

Land, breathe, then handle these

- ☐ **Message home that you've arrived.** Airport Wi-Fi works for this. Your family is refreshing the flight tracker — free them.
- ☐ **Get connected:** activate your U.S. SIM or eSIM within a day. Almost everything else — banking, campus apps, two-factor codes — depends on it.
- ☐ **Report to your international student office (DSO) and complete SEVIS check-in. ▲ critical**
This confirms you actually arrived and keeps your student status active. Schools set a deadline — treat it like a final exam date.
- ☐ **Learn your surroundings:** nearest grocery store, pharmacy, campus clinic, and transit stop.
- ☐ **Buy the boring essentials:** bedding, toiletries, a lamp, basic groceries. Cheap first, upgrade later.
- ☐ **Attend international student orientation.**
Yes, even if you're tired. It's where the friendships, the free food, and the answers are.

ONE MORE THING

Jet lag plus a new country plus no furniture can make anyone feel low in week one. That's normal, it's temporary, and it's not a sign you made the wrong choice. Eat something warm, sleep, and give yourself two weeks before judging anything.

This checklist gets you to the door. The Survival Kit gets you through your first year.

Before You Land™: The Ultimate International Student Survival Kit goes deep on everything this checklist can only mention — opening a U.S. bank account with no SSN, building credit from zero, surviving the port of entry, renting your first apartment without getting scammed, American classroom culture, working legally on your visa, taxes, winter, and more. It includes the complete **First 30 Days in America Planner** and the full **Packing Checklist** as bonuses.

Get it at the link where you found this checklist →

Stay connected

Created by **Nii Obodai** — say hello, ask your questions, and tag me when you land. I read everything.

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